



Southern California Mountaineer’s Association (SCMA) is a rock climbing group that was born when Sierra Club had to dissolve the old Rock Climbing Section (RSC) decades ago after they lost their outings insurance due to a number of factors. There’s still a fair amount of crossover between the groups though especially on the SCMA side there’s still some bad blood over the entire situation.

I’d heard about the SCMA RCSC (Rock Climbing Safety Course, hurray for acronyms) a few years before and I’d had it on my list as something I wanted to do but unfortunately it occurs at the same time as the Sierra Club Wilderness Travel Course (WTC) I instruct for and most years the outings conflict with each other.

I had checked late in 2009 and written off the 2010 class as the schedule was in conflict only to find at the last minute there had apparently been a change. So I signed up, was promptly put on a waiting list, and waited with baited breath until a few weeks before the course when I was told I made it in.

The class is structures as an orientation, 5 classes, and a graduation trip that take you from “This is a rope, tie in like this, kindly don’t drop your climbing partner” to (hopefully) being competent enough in multi-pitch climbing to join the club. Much of what was on the syllabus were things I’d already done with Sierra Club or elsewhere but it was a chance to get everything systematically and also to meet folks who might want to climb at my (admittedly very low) level.

Rock Climbing Safety Course 2010

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Session 0 – Orientation in Upland

Hanger 18 Climbing Gym, Upland, CA

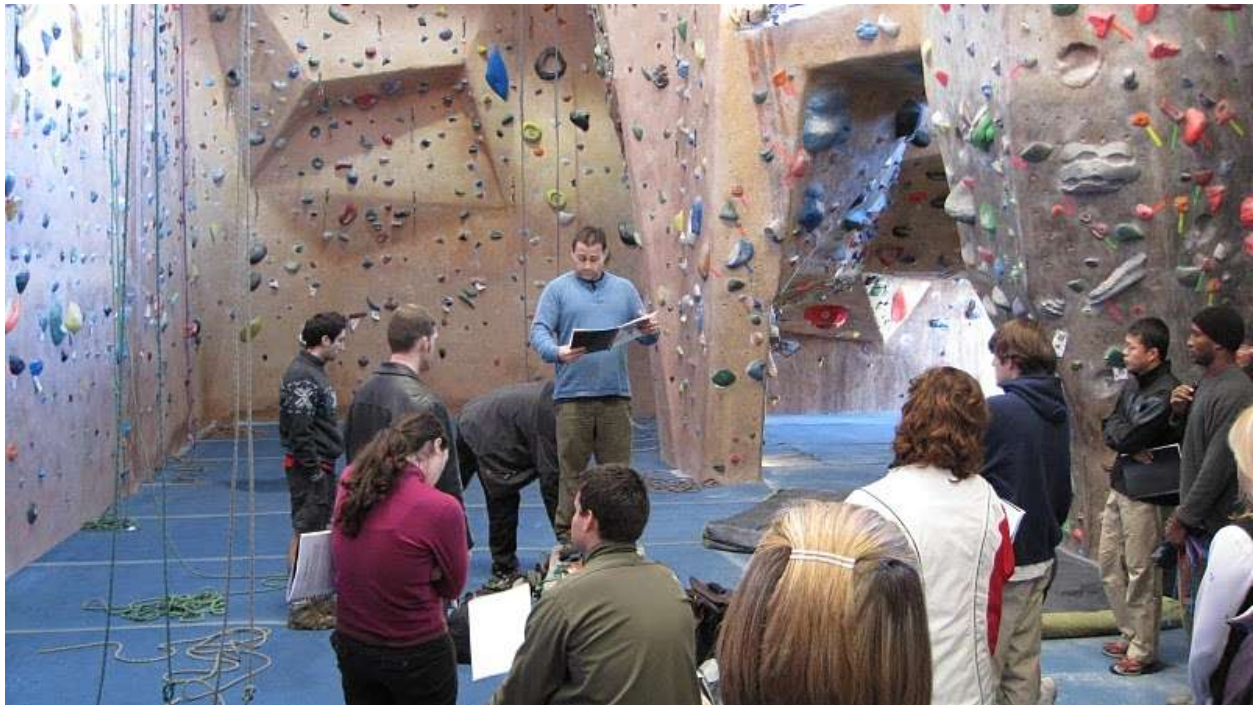
January 23rd, 2010

WTC had just had its second class meeting and I'd just spent the previous weekend out in Death Valley leading my Sierra club M-Rock provisional when January 23rd rolled around and it was the last time to start the RCSC.

Also in the class were Sherry, Dean, and Charles who were WTC students in Orange County last year and a few other folks I'd run into here and there. The hiking and mountaineering community is a rather small world so you run into a lot of the same folks. I probably knew about 1/3 of the SCMA instructors already from various places.

I met Sherry, Dean, and Charles down in Orange County and we all carpooled out to Upland to a rock gym called Hanger 18 to find out what we were in for. After a bit of trouble finding the place we pulled up and started chatting with folks while we waited for the gym to open.

We were eventually allowed inside (which proved to be damn cold for the dummies like me who had worn flip flops and climbing clothes) and our fearless leader Mike Sauter started the orientation.



It was a lot of explaining what the course would entail and a few very basic things about climbing.



After that we went over to the ropes and went over the basics in how to tie in and even got to climb very briefly.



After that we moved on to the series of knots we would be required to learn for the course. My Sierra Club rock rating served me quite well here as I knew pretty much all of them well enough to get by. Instead I was able to concentrate on picking up various tricks helping others where I could.



As soon as we split off for knot practice the majority of folks went outside where it was warmer.

And that was it for orientation. Everything was review so far and would largely be so for the next few classes but it was still a fun opportunity to meet a large group full of strangers.

Session 1: Rappelling At Rubidoux

Mount Rubidoux, Riverside, CA

February 6th, 2010

Orientation was all indoors at the rock gym but for the remainder of the class we would be outside in various urban climbing areas around Los Angeles. First up was Mt Rubidoux out in Riverside which was someplace I'd heard quite a bit about but hadn't had a chance to visit.

This being sunny Southern California it was slightly rainy when I met the others at the carpool point.



And by slightly rainy I mean we saw only two or three rafts go down the growing river that had previously been Lincoln Ave.

But hey, it'll stop by the time we get out to Riverside, right?



Ok, maybe not.



Any group that sees a downpour and decides hell with it, we go anyway gets bonus points in my book.

We helped carry some of the SCMA club gear up the hill on did a knot check off under some hastily assembled tarps managing to get only mostly wet. The growing puddles under our feet were rather refreshing actually.



The rain sadly died down after a while and we were able to get out and run through a quick belay test where I actually learned a rather disturbing belay trick I can't wait to unleash the next time I find myself going through some basic belay class.

After the instructors were reasonably confident we wouldn't drop our fellow climbers we did the logical thing during potential thunderstorm conditions and climbed up to the highest point on the rock wearing lots of metal gear in order to check for lightning.



Ah well, none today. Up top the instructors threw up some anchors and we went through instruction on the various permutations of rappelling. I tried to interest a few folks in the ball crushing (literally) dulfer method but got no takers.



Wet rock is fun to rappel down!



It also gave me what turned out to be one of my favorite shots so far this year:



Riverside (ie Valley of the Dirt People) when it's actually green! And there's a rainbow in the middle of the image if you look close.

We wrapped up at 5 or so and finished the day with the ever so pleasant post-climb beer at a local hangout called Lake Alice.



They even had a magician later in the night.



Eventually, sadly, we all returned to our cars and drove home for the long two week wait until the next class. Granted the following day I did a solo hike out in the desert that gave me a rather entertaining

tale about how I was tracked down a ridge by a mountain lion, followed around a park a ride by an odd man sometime after midnight in Riverside, and then pulled over for suspected DUI in the middle of the night but eh, that's just my usual life.

Session 2: Prusiking at Stony Point

Stony Point, Chatsworth, CA

February 20th, 2010



This time we met at the local climber hangout of Chatsworth, Stony Point. So called because...well it's a pig pile of rock sitting out by the side of a road in Chatsworth that's vaguely pointy shaped. It offers true urban climbing in that instead of looking out for natural dangers like snakes and cholla you mostly try not to step in the trash, discarded clothing, old condoms, ect. But it does have its pretty parts on the odd occasions when it hasn't been set on fire in the last 6 months.

Actually other than the drive involved for those of us in South Orange County my biggest issue with Stony Point is the lack of bathroom facilities. So you try and find a bush on the busy hillside, think you're in an isolated little corner where you won't unleash a yellow flood on someone climbing below, start to take care of business and then a girl scout or someone will pop around the corner and *BAM* you're a sex offender.

Or maybe that's just with me.



Anyway, we arrived and there was the usual early morning milling about as ropes were set up for the rappelling check off.



We actually got to go over some decent overhangs this time which is much more fun as there's the inevitable moment where you have to make a move over the lip and risk smashing your face into the rock.



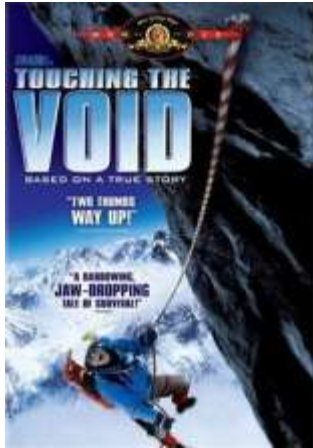
Since it wasn't pouring rain this time we actually got to climb a bit while the others were busy finishing the rappel check off.



That afternoon we started the new topic, prusiking up a rope! This is a rather fun skill that lets you ascend a rope in the event that you for some reason can't continue down.



For a good example see the movie *Touching The Void*.



I'd done this before but not extensively so I was first in line to fiddle my way up a rope.



That also meant I had a large amount of free time once I was finished and the remainder of the class still had to go so I grabbed some other students and went over to top rope.



That's an interesting belay posture that will actually get you kicked out of most climbing gyms.



5 pm rolled around much too soon and we finished with some inspiring words from our fearless leader Mike which amounted to "Gee, you guys trust us an amazing amount..."

Then on to the post-climbing margaritas



I'm starting to see a pattern.

Session 3: Prusiking, Fallen Climber, and Potential Electrocution at Rubidoux

March 5th, 2010

Mount Rubidoux, Riverside, CA



Again we were at Rubidoux but this time it was straight to the top instead of wasting time part way up. Turns out the mountain is rather steep when you're carrying ropes and all your climbing gear.





We were joined by the marines who we unfortunately could not convince to carry any of our gear.



This is Sherry's downtime pose. Mine is more along the lines up jumping up and down like I have to pee or just have waaay too much energy.

First order of the day was to check off on prusiking up a rope with the extra challenge of doing it over an overhang as well. This is fun because it invariably results in skinned knuckles and as we all know, if you're not bleeding then you're not having fun.



It was so much fun I was sorely tempted to do something intentionally dumb and fail the check off so I could do it again but I decided that wasn't fair to the others. Instead I wandered off to climb with other folks who had already finished.



Danica has been an awesome climber ever since that radioactive spider bite. However, she has a secret weakness to belayers who make her laugh while she's trying difficult moves *innocent whistle*

The afternoon topic was something called the fallen climber tie off. I'd done something by that same name for my Sierra Club rock check-off but this was pretty much completely different.



Basically it allows you to go from belaying your climbing partner to getting out of the system completely and leaving them dangling up there while you go for help. Or coffee. It's useful if your climbing somewhere and your partner takes a bad fall and needs help. Or if they're taking too long climbing a pitch and you really need to go to the bathroom, Starbucks, home to sleep ("I'll come back tomorrow, don't worry!")



About this time the clouds were getting rather dark and we started to hear thunder and even see lightning strike in the distance. Even better we were again standing on the very top of the highest rock in the area wearing large amount of metal.

I can usually be counted on to spew a number of rather uncomfortable and unpleasant facts about any given situation and potential lighting strikes are no exception. My group members were somehow less than comforted.

Sadly the lightning kept its distance (there goes yet another chance to appear in Accidents In North American Mountaineering 2010, maybe next year) and we retired to Lake Alice to celebrate our lack of electrical burns.



Session 4: Anchors, Anchors, and more Anchors!

March 27th, 2010

Mount Rubidoux, Riverside, CA



For once there wasn't even a chance of rain as we headed out once more for Mt. Rubidoux in Riverside but we did have winds nearly hard enough to blow us off the rock. Fortunately we were there to learn how to construct anchors to which we would trust our continued existence (or at least our lack of plummeting to serious injury.)



Other than the wind it was a beautiful day.

We had all been admonished by our fearless leader Mike via email to be on time, “If you’re not up top at the cross at 8 am you’ll be assigned to group 4, and we don’t have a group 4.” Fair enough so I made sure to be plenty early and promptly sat up there until 8:20 or so when the instructors showed up with all the club gear they had carried from the bottom. Instructional oops!

The topic of the day was all about anchors so instead of the usual testing of the skills we learned last week we were divided into groups of 3 and sent off to stations.

The stations were divided into active protection (ie cams)



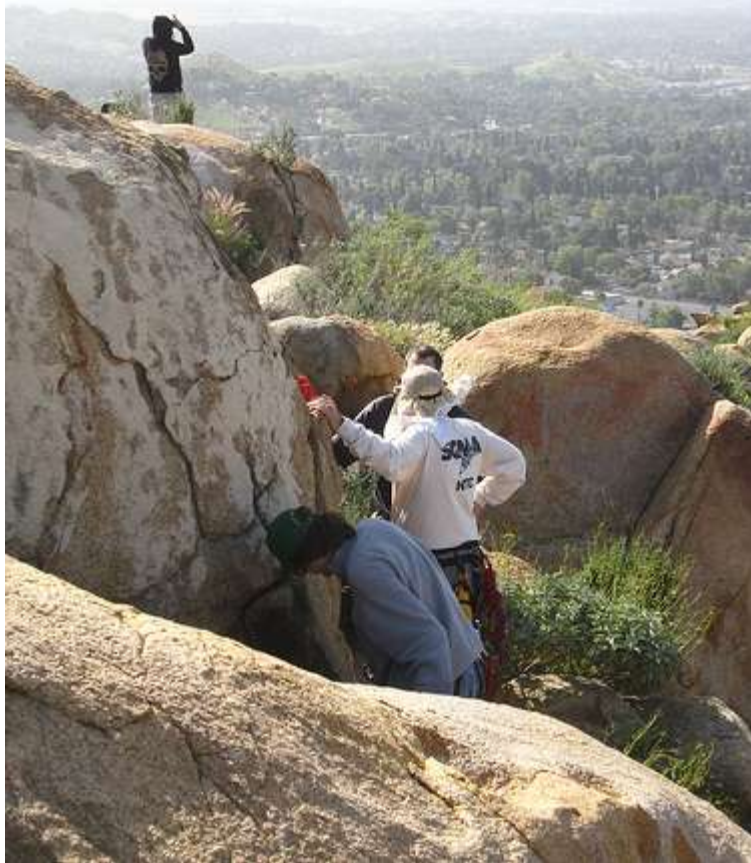
Primitive protection (slings, static ropes, ect)



And kung-fu. I mean passive protection like nuts and hexes.



I was at active protection first. We spent time wandering around shoving cams into cracks and seeing how well they stayed.



I had my shiny new Black Diamond cam #1 to play with and promptly shaved off a good section of one of my knuckles testing a placement. Since you're not really having fun unless you're bleeding it could now be assumed I was enjoying myself quite a lot.



On the next rock over was a private group doing rappelling. Every now and then over the wind I could hear the shriek of a terrified rappeller but since there was no squishy sounding splat afterwards I assume everything went fine.

We also had a brief demo of multi pitch rock climbing as a teaser for session 5.



Next was primitive anchors where another student and I set up a rough but serviceable anchor using nothing but slings and our cordelletes (fancy rock climber talk for 25 ft long piece of static cord). I learned a few new tricks at this station which were rather interesting.

And last but not least we went over to passive protection where we played around with each other's nuts.



Mind out of the gutter folks, climbing nuts.



After we had finished all three stations the entire class came back together for our exam for the day. We were instructed to set an anchor using one of each of the three methods and then rappel off of it. If we survived we passed.



I of course shunned the obvious locations and instead insisted on trying something interesting. So with a slightly less than enthusiastic Charles and Dean in tow we went over to a rather non-ideal location where the nearest anchor points were a good 20 feet back and proceeded to set up a rather interesting franken-anchor using just about every piece of gear we had with us.



It's always good when the instructors' comments are along the lines of "Well, I've never seen anything quite like that but I can't see anything really wrong with it."

My partners were so overwhelmingly confident in our abilities that they insisted I go over the edge first to test the anchor.



And since the next shot isn't me sitting in a hospital with a leg cast you can probably guess it held.



My stalwart partners went over next and by this time we had a bit of an audience below. They wandered off as soon as it became apparent we weren't about to plunge to our untimely deaths at their feet.

By that time it was 5 pm which meant we had to hurry.



Beer inspection time at Lake Alice!

I didn't stay too late this time as I was doing a 19 mile hike out past Temecula the next morning which was going to make for a rather early morning.

Session 5: Simulated Multi-Pitch at Big Rock

April 10th, 2010

Big Rock, Lake Perris, CA



April 10th rolled around and it was time for the 5th and final RCSC class. This time we would be out in the Lake Perris area at a climber hangout called Big Rock. So named because it's a rock, that's big.

The day got off to a bit of a rough start when we found that the Ramona Expressway, the only way most of us had to access Big Rock, was closed due to a fatal accident and that the detour signs, all two of them, could be rated somewhere below worthless in helping you find a way past the closed section. Cue a large number of folks pulling u turns, hitting dead ends, and generally acting lost.

I set off through the boonies and made it to the correct area only to find a handful of others waiting by a locked gate. Eventually most everyone found their way and we made it past the gate only to find there were no fee envelopes at this entrance leaving us to wonder if we were all going to get rather pricey tickets.



Eventually we had everything sorted out and hiked in to the actual climbing area only about an hour late. And we found...a big rock.



After words of wisdom by our more-awake-then-we-were leaders were divided into three groups and sent off to do three different stations.



First up for my group was the dry run of the quasi multi-pitch climbing we'd be doing that afternoon. The goal was to run us through the various actions we'd need that day and more importantly during the evaluation climbs that we'd all be doing once graduation was over.



When it was time to rotate our group pulled the dreaded fallen climber tie off station. Again, the fallen climber tie off is useful if you need to escape a belay because your partner is injured or just climbing really slow and you really need to go get a cup of coffee / chat with those cute girls climbing the next rock over. After my repeated comments to that effect Eric decided maybe he didn't want to climb with me.



Some were more easily excited by this station than others.



Last but not least was advanced anchor building concentrating on setting various types of anchors while you're hanging off the side of a rock face as opposed to just standing on the ground like last week.



After we finished the rotation it was lunch time. This was spiced up considerably when the following critter showed up:



LeRoy, who happened to be sitting right by the snake, calmly announced it's presence by jumping a good 10 ft in the air and making a rather curious sound that no doubt came from concern for his fellow climbers.



After lunch it was time for the real fun, multi-pitch climbing!

Well, kind of anyway.

They had set up a route where we would climb up from the ground towards an instructor situated up on the rock who had us on belay. Once we reached them another instructor even higher up would take over and belay us up to the top. Meanwhile we had a rope attached to our haul loop and as we passed each instructor they would use that to belay up the person below us.

End result we got to climb two pitches instead of one in a steady queue.



The biggest disappointment for me was just reaching the second station and realizing there wasn't a third to climb up to. Ah well, at least there's the eval climbs to look forward to.

(I'm the guy in green half way up in the picture above.)



An interesting feature of Big Rock was the lack of handholds and such. You end up just using friction on these tiny micro ridges to get yourself up. Quite fun but it requires a bit of a mental shift from the usual style of climbing.



After finishing my climb I then mostly hung around and took pictures of others as they queued up for their climbs.



Ha! The view from the bottom was rather intimidating.





In addition there was a top rope set up nearby that we could climb when we were done.



I climbed this once then went back to taking pictures. After all, I was supposed to be resting for a 34 mile hike the next day.

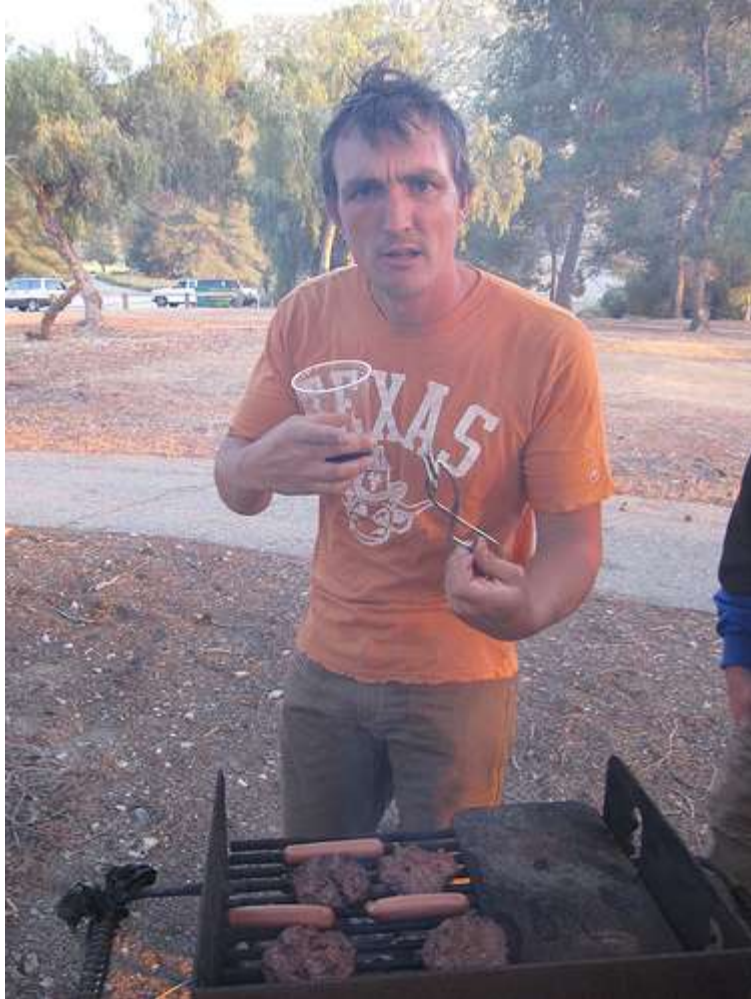
Eventually 5 pm rolled around, then 6 pm, then 6:20 pm and it was time for the other most important activity of the day, the post-climb potluck!



There was a nice selection of food and barbequed meat. As usual one took care not to get your hands in between anyone and the food items lest you lose a limb.



There may have been beer as well.



The barbeque instruments were somewhat primitive but somehow we managed.

The party broke up by 8 pm as that was when they locked the gates (potentially locking any slowpokes inside.) A rather enthusiastic mass exodus ensued.

As usual I had plans for the following day which this time consisted of leading a private 34 mile hike out in the Santa Ana Mountains that was going to start oh so early.

Graduation! Sierra Time Baby!

April 24th & 25th, 2010

Alabama Hills, Lone Pine, CA



And at last we'd finished the class and it was time to party! And climb! And where better to do those things than in the shadow of the Sierra. SCMA had graciously arranged a campsite at Alabama Hills, a rock climbing area just above Lone Pine off the 395.

As opposed to most weekends (where I fly home and spend 5 hours solo driving to a remote trailhead in the Sierra) I was fortunate enough to have a carpool this time as Sherry and Addie were both willing to drive up late Friday night with me. We left Orange County around 8 pm and made a beeline for Lone Pine.



We arrived around 12:30 in the morning just in time to see the group around the fire pit break up and head for their sleeping bags.

We found a relatively empty campsite, pulled in our vehicle, and sacked out just as soon as we could set up our tents. Me being lazy just threw out a bivy sack and climbed inside.

5 hours later we all bounded out of our sleeping bags with endless enthusiasm to meet the day.



Or maybe that was just me.



The area was absolutely beautiful. The rocks were a short drive away and even from our campsite we had an awesome view of the snow capped Sierra. We could even make out Whitney in places (high point of the continental United States!)

People started emerging from tents, campers, and vehicles sometime around 7 am.

The scheduled 7:45 yoga class started promptly at 8:12 or so led by Mike and Alyssa.



As this was going on Dan was set up behind Alyssa taking part in full view of the other participants.



It appeared from the sidelines that everyone's balance somehow became much worse whenever they focused on him instead of her. Hmm.

We all were responsible for our own breakfasts and after a rousing speech by Mike wrapping up the class we were off to climb.







This was the 5th lead I did and the hardest of the day. It was a 5.7 on Tall Wall.

There was food, drink...



..odd instrument playing.....



...impressionable young children around...

And a rather nice ceremony where all us graduates received certificates and t-shirts. As many folks have found out I do almost anything for a t-shirt.

As it got later more and more folks turned in leaving just the true, the jovial, the slightly tipsy...



As it approached 3 am things got...creative...



Sometime after 3 am I stumbled back to my campsite and managed to crawl into my bivy.



7 am the next morning I leapt (or crawled) out of my bivy and wandered back to the main campsite. We had been promised a pancake breakfast in order to get us all out of bed at a decent time.





Having recently attending Red Rock Rendezvous out near Vegas which also promoted a pancake breakfast I must say the Sauter version was far superior. We had mounds of pancakes, eggs, sausage, some weird veggie meat thing, fruit, and coffee.

After having gorged ourselves



As we drive out to the Corridors climbing area we came across a rather cute sight of someone setting up an easy anchor and letting their little daughter climb.

My car had to leave around noon in order to make it back to Orange County early enough to return our rental car so I was anxious to get out on the rock.

And having led 5 climbs yesterday I wasn't content to wait for the instructors to set up top ropes especially since I had all my own rope and associated gear. So with a few folks in tow I set out looking for something to climb.

Using a somewhat lacking guide book we went looking for a climb called Birthday Buttcrack. We found this:



It looked somewhat like the badly rendered line drawing we had and the bottom looked doable. From the bottom...

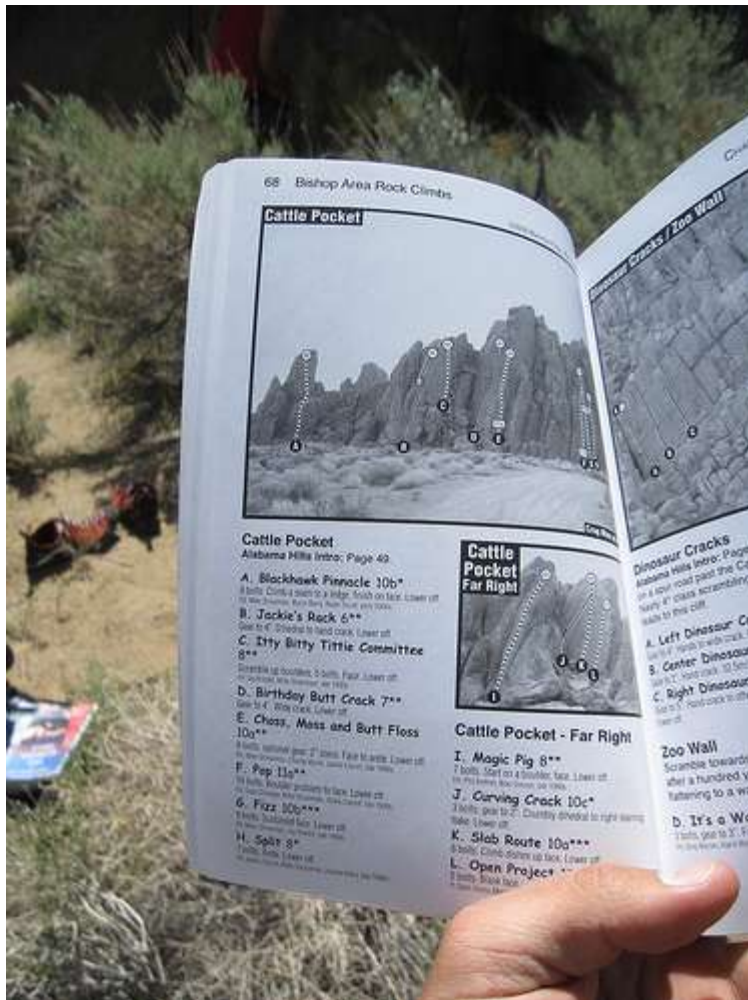


Turns out the crux is right at the top. Having gotten all the way up there I wasn't about to bail so kept at it through several lead falls and thanks to my infinity patient belay Sherry I eventually reached the anchor, set a top rope anchor in record speed, and was lower down.



Note the blood! Now I'm having fun.

After I got down we located another guide book with better illustrations. Turns out the route was actually Blackhawk Pinnacle and rated 5.10b.



Oops.

Just for clarification, the Tall Wall lead I did the previous day was 5.7. This was a 5.10b. The ratings between go 5.7 -> 5.8 -> 5.9 -> 5.10a -> 5.10b. I generally climb around the 5.9 level.

To quote O'Donnell's Laws of Cartoon Motion (Esquire, June 1980)

"Any body suspended in space will remain in space until made aware of its situation. (The character walks off the edge of a cliff, remains suspended in midair, and doesn't fall until he looks down.)"

I am fully convinced I managed to make lead the route only because I didn't know it was actually a 5.10b. But yeehaw!



I decided to sit on the ground and pretend I was exhausted for a bit while a few other folks attempted the climb.

Sadly due to our pending rental car return deadline we soon had to pack it up and head for home.

The next step for all of us RCSC students is to schedule two eval climbs in order to join SCMA as associate members. I'm currently working ot schedule them around my rather busy Sierra Club trip schedule.

Eval #1. Multi-Up-The-What-Now?

June 12th, 2010

Whitney Portal, Premier Butress

Summer was officially on though late seasons storms had resulted in enough snow in the high Sierra to keep us out of the high country without snow gear. Still between leading Sierra Club backpacking trips, attending a few as a participant, and volunteering to help instruct for another mountaineering course I was booked solid for every weekend between April and the end of October.

In order to complete the RCSC I had two multipitch trad climbs to complete with evaluators. Fortunately things worked out and I was able to arrange one of my post-RCSC eval climbs for the weekends I was scheduled to drive out to Boise to swap my old vehicle for the new one I'd purchased.

Mike Sauter had been nice enough to put me in contact with Dave German up in Bishop since he knew (well, I probably mentioned about 30 times during the class) that I went up to the Sierra for trips all the time.

Things started off with the usual complications and as I was driving up from Orange County to the Sierra late at night I received a call from Dave warning me the weather wasn't looking good and I may want to abort my drive. Not one to be put off easily by weather I pushed to go and see how things turned out the next morning.

I pulled in to Alabama Hills sometime after 1 am, threw out my bivy, and quickly fell asleep. Or tried to anyway, unfortunately the large amount of caffeine I consumed to make the drive made it rather hard to doze off asleep.

Sometime around 2 am things improved yet again as raindrop started to fall on me. I waited as they grew more insistent and finally climbed out of my bivy, threw my bags back in the truck, then flipped my bivy upside down and climbed back inside.



So after a short and somewhat less than restful night I awoke to weather that wasn't exactly threatening but wasn't promising either. I could see rain or snow falling in the distance.

I met Dave and we headed up the road to Whitney Portal determined to at least make a go of the climb.



Dave lives in Bishop and among other things volunteers with the local search and rescue operation. He's done quite a bit of climbing but hasn't been as active lately due to other commitments.



We had a short hike from where we parked to where we started climbing. The initial pitch was quite approachable and after the initial review of signals and such we were off.



The view was downright spectacular. I was a bit limited on picture taking time since there were just the two of us and we were constantly in motion.



A few hours later we reached the top of the Premier Buttress route.



On the last pitch the wind had really picked up and I was glad for my long johns and fleece top. I gathered the rope and tossed it down to get ready for the rappel and the rope promptly came out horizontal due to the high wind.



Dave adjusted and headed down first to the next rap station.



After that I took the lead.



We made it down without incident and returned to the car. I bought Dave lunch in Big Pine as a thank you and I was off up the road to Boise. I actually made it in to Oregon that night and Boise early the next morning.

Eval #2. Well, Not Quite As Planned.

June 19th, 2010

Tahquitz Peak, White Maiden's Walkaway

Eval #2 was planned for the following weekend after I drove my new vehicle back in to town.

Unfortunately the person I had originally arranged to climb with had an injury which did not heal in time but fortunately he pointed me to Pam and Ben Chapman who graciously allowed me to join their already planned climb with Lori from the class.

So after leaving Boise Thursday night and stopping briefly on Friday to bag an easy peak in the Sierra I arrived back in Orange County, slept a few hours, then woke up and headed to Idyllwild for an early morning start from Humber Park.



Ben is quite the accomplished climber and mountaineer and oddly enough I'd actually met him and Pam last year at Echo Cliffs where they'd been putting up a route in the Grotto. Small world.



The approach to Tahquitz is a good 45 minutes or so of climbing from the parking lot. Loaded down with gear and ropes it's oh so much fun and gives you a good chance to warm up.





The start was rather unassuming. This is one of the easier climbs on Tahquitz ringing in at 5.4 or 5.6 depending on the guide book. The plan was to spice it up a bit near the top with a harder 5.7+ variation to finish things off.



The belay stations were somewhat...brushy.



And just to prove I was actually on the climb:



Behind us there was another SCMA group climbing. Say hello to Suzanne. She's wearing a dress because that evening was an annual SCMA event called the Dinner Climb where people headed up the rock in formal wear.









The climb was very easy until we did the variation at the top.



That was fun.



Up top we ran into a motley assortment of other characters such as Cory. Note the formal wear.





We then joined the dinner climb. As I was driving up to Big Bear that night to take some friends climbing the next day I'd intended to leave early but ended up hanging out and chatting.



I was somewhat underdressed.



Finally the party was over and I descended with the others.



Lori and I bought Pam and Ben dinner at the local always awesome Las Casitas as a thank you for the eval and then I left for Big Bear around 9:30 pm. Unfortunately I didn't arrive at Holcomb Valley until

sometime around 2 am. For someone who absolutely hates being tired I seem to make an awful lot of late night drives.

So that's it as far as the RCSC. After the paperwork (you can really tell the SCMA came from Sierra Club) from the Whitney Portal and Tahquitz climbs are processed I should be an official Associate Member of SCMA, t-shirt and all.